

WORKHORSES

The majority of notebooks owned by upper-management in most companies form this category. Executive looks, essential features, a good balance between processing power and battery life, good pricing, etc., are some of the things to look for in such laptops.

In all, 12 laptops from eight different brands made it to this category. Three Compaq notebooks; two from Toshiba; and one each from IBM and Acer made up the international brands. Zenith contributed with their Strategist and Director models, while Wipro sent in two notebooks. A new entrant—MSI, known for great motherboards—also sent in one laptop.

The laptops were all designed to cater to two sets of people—the more mature and elegant looking notebooks for senior management, and the peppy-looking ones to cater to the young blood rising in the corporate ranks.

Features

Almost all the laptops here were based on the Pentium M Centrino platform. Only the Compaq P2514AT, Compaq P2563AI and the Toshiba Satellite A60 models used either a Pentium 4 or Celeron processor.

Most of the Centrino-based notebooks integrated a 1.5 GHz processor; Acer went one step further and used a 1.8 GHz processor and Zenith's Strategist model used a 1.7 GHz Processor. The IBM's R50 processor was the lowest rated at 1.4 GHz processor—still a decent clock speed.

Centrino platform-based notebooks offer long battery life, great performance, and wireless connectivity

256 MB seems to be the norm for RAM. A few exceptions—the Compaq P2514AT, and both the Zenith models—ship with only 128 MB of RAM. We asked for the Zenith laptops to be upgraded to 256 MB, since that is a pre-requisite to run Windows XP, at least in our opinion. The prices quoted in this category for the Zenith models include the cost of upgrading to 256 MB RAM. Acer was the best of the lot, and offered 512 MB of RAM.

Zenith's Strategist model stood apart from the rest with its 15.4-inch wide-screen TFT display—wide screens are really helpful when working with applications such as Excel. Four of the notebooks had 14-inch displays—the IBM R50, the Compaq 2514AT, the Toshiba Tecra M2V and the Zenith Director. The rest had 15-inch displays.

The quality of the display screens on the Toshiba Tecra, Compaq's V1040AP and IBM's R50 were the best—noticeable when watching fast action videos.

All the laptops offered three or four USB ports. A port that seems to be gaining in popularity is the Firewire port, making it easy for imaging professionals to connect their digital cameras and other high-end digital imaging stuff.

Infrared (IR), though outdated, is still the preferred wireless communication protocol, and is found on a lot of laptops. Though great to sync your mobile phones, handhelds etc, it is a definite no-no when transferring large files. Only the MSI and Zenith notebooks lacked an IR port.

With the wide acceptance of Bluetooth in

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